CONNECT DAILY

Thursday 29 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- The morning after: Chancellor John Healey's first Budget landed yesterday with little new money specifically for schools, and the OBR's forecast flags a widening SEND funding gap - full DfE detail is still to follow.
- Treat any school-funding figures doing the rounds today as provisional until the Department for Education publishes its own breakdown of the settlement.
- Genuinely quiet locally too - Sheffield schools stay closed for half term until Monday 2 November, so no new city-level stories broke in the last 24 hours.
- Reminder: the NEU's formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload is still open and closes 15 December.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term continues.

30 Oct 2026 — First Schools Budget Support Grant 2026 payments due to go out to local authorities.

15 Dec 2026 — NEU's formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload closes.

Early 2027 — UK City of Culture 2029 winner announced; Sheffield is one of four finalists.

NATIONAL POLICY & FUNDING

▪ **Budget lands light for schools.** Chancellor John Healey's first Budget, delivered yesterday alongside the OBR's updated forecast, included few new schools-specific announcements. The OBR's figures point to councils' cumulative SEND deficits continuing to widen sharply over the next couple of years - treat the exact scale as a reported, not independently verified, figure until DfE's own breakdown lands. Commentary also flagged that mainstream per-pupil funding is on track to fall in real terms, as funding is held flat against falling pupil numbers, with no new grant confirmed to cover schools' rising minimum-wage costs. (Tes)

→ **For your school:** *Hold off on budget-planning assumptions until the DfE publishes its own schools-funding breakdown of yesterday's settlement.*

▪ **SEND still the pressure point.** Education Secretary Lucy Powell inherits a department where SEND cost pressures remain the dominant budget issue for schools and councils alike; expect more detail on how the Budget settlement feeds into the wider SEND reform programme in the coming weeks rather than today. (Schools Week)

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

▪ **Still half term.** Sheffield schools remain closed for the autumn half term until Monday 2 November. Academies can set their own dates, so it's worth double-checking individual school calendars before assuming a city-wide return. (Sheffield City Council (via SaveMyExams term dates))

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

£5.7bn

The OBR's forecast for English councils' cumulative SEND overspend by 2027-28, cited in Budget

coverage - a directional figure to watch rather than a confirmed exact one.

OBR, via Tes Budget 2026 coverage

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.